A cleaned dataset of signed opinion articles in U.S. newspapers, 1980–2024

Data descriptor, version 1.0 (2026-11-08). Derived from the raw table described in `docs/datasheet_raw.md`.

Abstract

The dataset holds 402,498 opinion articles signed by at least one person, published 1980–2024 in ten U.S. newspapers with the highest circulation, and the 85,403 authors who signed them. Articles and authors are separate tables joined by a link table, since an article can have several authors and an author many articles. The dataset is derived from 1,377,766 rows parsed from ProQuest US Newsstream exports by a sequence of exclusions, each row leaving for exactly one reason. Authors were read from the bylines by explicit rules; name variants of one author were merged by a rule, and the doubtful cases were decided in a manual review carried out by a large language model, which is documented here.

1. Background and summary

The dataset supports the study of how economists communicate with the public through newspaper opinion pieces. It keeps only what that study needs: opinion pieces, from the queried newspapers, with text, signed by a person.

Articles	402,498
Authors	85,403
Article–author links	450,748
Newspapers	10
Publication years	1980–2024
Articles with one author	93.1%
Authors with one article	50,529 (59.2%)

2. Methods

2.1 Selection of articles

Every parsed row gets exactly one reason, so the counts add up. The first three exclusions give the shared raw table; the others leave only the cleaned dataset (Figure 1).

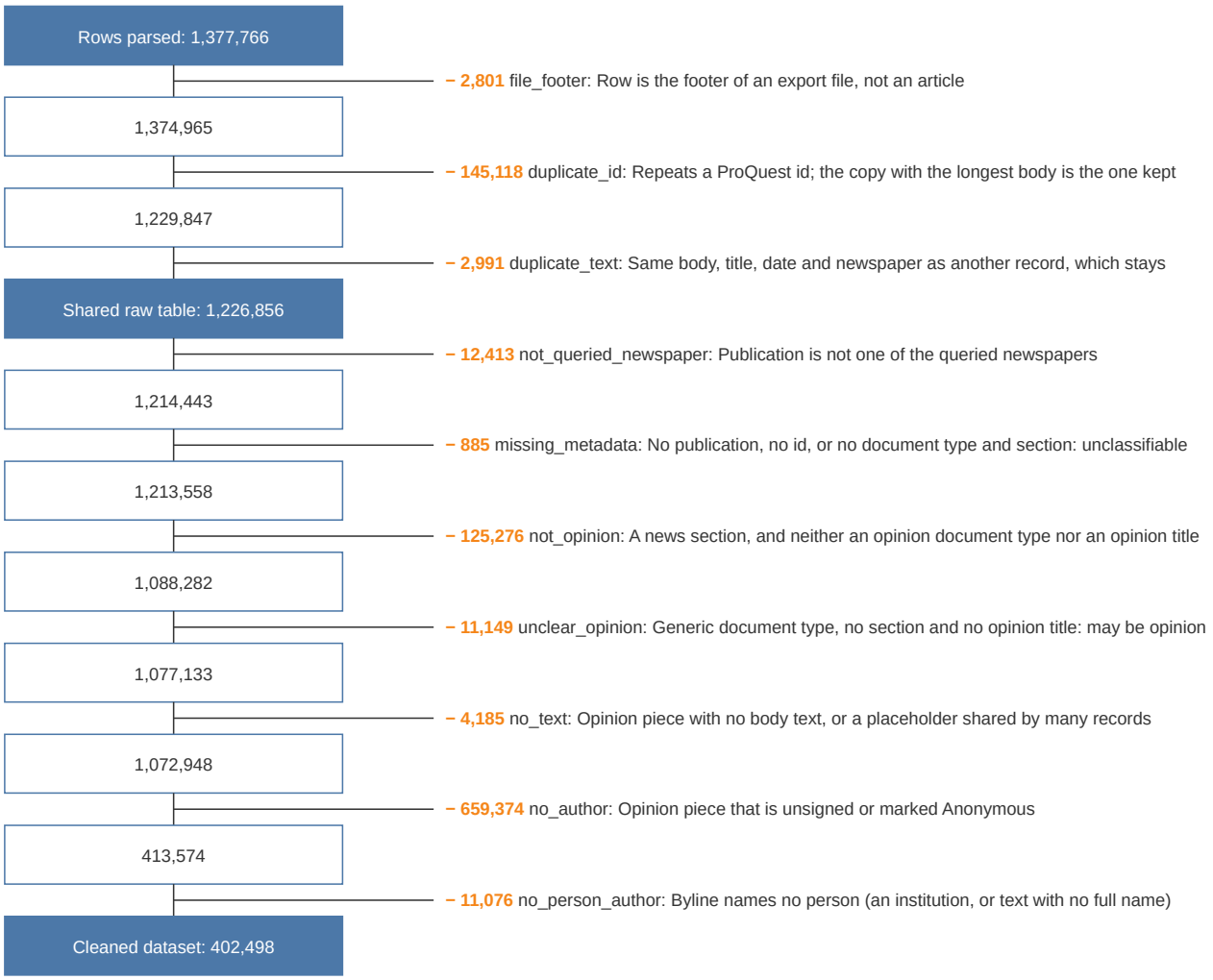


Figure 1. Exclusions from the rows parsed to the cleaned dataset.

Step	Left out	Records	Remaining
Rows parsed			1,377,766
file_footer	Row is the footer of an export file, not an article	2,801	1,374,965
duplicate_id	Repeats a ProQuest id; the copy with the longest body is the one kept	145,118	1,229,847
duplicate_text	Same body, title, date and newspaper as another record, which stays	2,991	1,226,856
not_queried_newspaper	Publication is not one of the queried newspapers	12,413	1,214,443
missing_metadata	No publication, no id, or no document type and section: unclassifiable	885	1,213,558
not_opinion	A news section, and neither an opinion document type nor an opinion title	125,276	1,088,282
unclear_opinion	Generic document type, no section and no opinion title: may be opinion	11,149	1,077,133
no_text	Opinion piece with no body text, or a placeholder shared by many records	4,185	1,072,948
no_author	Opinion piece that is unsigned or marked Anonymous	659,374	413,574
no_person_author	Byline names no person (an institution, or text with no full name)	11,076	402,498

- **Opinion:** a record is opinion if its document type, its section or its title marks it as commentary, editorial, op-ed or letters. Records with no such mark are left out, either as news (`not_opinion`) or, when they have no section, as undecided (`unclear_opinion`).

- **Newspapers:** the ten queried newspapers, print and online editions.
- **Text and author:** an article needs body text and a byline that names at least one person. A body carried by twenty or more different articles is a placeholder ("text not available"), not text (`no_text`). ProQuest's "Anonymous" and missing bylines are unsigned (`no_author`); a byline that names only an institution is `no_person_author`.

2.2 Reading the bylines

- `;` separates authors. A suffix standing alone joins the name before it, and a given name cut off from its family name is rejoined (`Lewis; , Flora`).
- A part is a person if it reads as `Family, Given[, Suffix]` or `Given Family`: two to five capitalised name words, no institution word, no digits. Titles and offices before the name (Dr., Sen., State Rep) and degrees after it (MD, PhD) are dropped. One word is never taken as a name.
- If a part does not read as a name, a full name at its start is recovered (`Jane Doe. Springfield`, `Jane Doe is a columnist`), and co-authors that the export scrambled are put back (`Doe, Jane Roe and Ann` is Jane Roe and Ann Doe).
- Of 450,748 links, 430,599 (95.5%) were read as written, 15,681 were recovered and 4,468 come from the manual review (section 2.4). Each link records how it was read.

2.3 Deciding that two names are one author

- **Name key:** case, accents, periods, apostrophes, hyphens and spaces are ignored, so spelling variants and ProQuest's stray spaces give one key. Middle names and suffixes are kept.
- **Rule:** names with the same first and family name are one author when their middle names and suffixes do not contradict each other (one is missing, or one is the initial of the other, compared name by name) and they share at least one newspaper. One contradiction among such names stops every merge among them.
- **Result:** 89,122 name variants for 85,403 authors; 3,111 variants were merged by the rule and 608 by the manual review.
- **Not merged:** 5,418 pairs of look-alike authors are listed, not merged (section 3.5).

2.4 Manual review by a large language model

No person reviewed the cases. Each case was read and decided one by one by a large language model (Claude, Anthropic), without web search, under written instructions: merge only with supporting evidence, and answer "unsure" when in doubt. The evidence shown for an author was its newspapers, its years and two headlines.

Reviewed	Cases	Outcome
Byline parts (ambiguous, holding a place or publication word, or read as nobody)	4,434	2,722 corrected, 1,074 not a person, 575 kept as read, 63 unsure
Pairs of look-alike authors with two or more articles each	1,601	634 same person, 586 different, 381 unsure

- **Models:** most cases were decided by Claude Sonnet run as subagents; the rest, and the checks, by Claude Fable 5.1. The reviewer of every decision is recorded in the review files.
- **Checks:** random samples of the decisions of the first and third rounds (about 175) were read again by a second model, which rewrote two suffixes and changed no decision; an independent audit of the output then found credits of interviewers and illustrators taken as authors, which were corrected. The set was checked for contradictions. The rounds are described in the README of the review files.
- **How decisions are applied:** they are data read by the pipeline, never edits to the rules. A corrected byline and a merge by review are marked `manual_review`. A pair judged different is never merged by the rule. A pair

judged unsure is left to the rule: it stays apart, with its verdict in the list of look-alike pairs, unless the rule later merges it.
- **Limit:** a language model can be wrong, above all for authors it knows nothing about. The decisions and their reasons are delivered with the dataset so they can be audited.

3. Data records

Five CSV files (UTF-8, comma-separated). The article text is ProQuest-licensed: the dataset is for internal use among the project's researchers.

3.1 `articles.csv`

One row per article, keyed by `doc_id` (the ProQuest id). It has every column of the raw table (see its datasheet) except `is_footer`, plus:

Column	Type	Content
`newspaper`	string	One of the ten newspapers, the same for its print and online editions
`edition`	string	`print`, `online` or `pre-1997` (ProQuest's label for older records)

`author` keeps the byline as exported; the authors read from it are in the tables below.

3.2 `authors.csv`

Column	Type	Content
`author_id`	integer	Key, numbered in the order of the name keys
`name`	string	Commonest spelling of the author's main name variant, given name first
`articles`	integer	Articles signed
`name_variants`	integer	Name variants merged into this author

3.3 `author_names.csv`

Column	Type	Content
`author_id`	integer	Author the variant belongs to
`name`	string	The variant, given name first
`name_key`	string	Its key (section 2.3)
`articles`	integer	Articles in which the variant appears
`rule`	string	`main` (the variant that names the author), `shared_newspaper` (merged by the rule) or `manual_review`

3.4 `article_authors.csv`

The many-to-many link.

Column	Type	Content
`doc_id`	integer	Article
`author_id`	integer	Author
`position`	integer	Order in the byline, from 1

Column	Type	Content
`read`	string	`as_written`, `recovered` or `manual_review` (section 2.2)

3.5 `author_candidates.csv`

Pairs of authors that look alike and are not merged.

Column	Type	Content
`author_id_a`, `name_a`, `articles_a`		First author of the pair
`author_id_b`, `name_b`, `articles_b`		Second author
`kind`	string	`no_shared_newspaper` (compatible names never in the same newspaper), `conflicting_names` (middle names or suffixes contradict within the group), `one_letter_apart` (keys one letter apart in the same newspaper), `nickname` (first names that are short forms of each other, in the same newspaper), `swapped_names` (given and family name the other way round) or `apart_by_review`
`review`	string	`different`, `unsure` or `not_reviewed`. A verdict on a pair that no rule lists any more is kept in the review files only

4. Contents

4.1 Newspapers

Newspaper	Articles	Print	Online	Pre-1997	Share
Washington Post	108,698	50,087	47,732	10,879	27.0%
New York Times	94,066	64,258	29,808	0	23.4%
Los Angeles Times	58,730	33,150	10,114	15,466	14.6%
Boston Globe	41,302	23,365	5,789	12,148	10.3%
Wall Street Journal	38,217	1,963	36,254	0	9.5%
Chicago Tribune	20,401	4,331	12,594	3,476	5.1%
Newsday	20,019	20,019	0	0	5.0%
USA Today	19,179	2,892	16,287	0	4.8%
Tampa Bay Times	1,526	98	1,428	0	0.4%
Star Tribune	360	360	0	0	0.1%
Total	402,498	200,523	160,006	41,969	100.0%

4.2 Decades

Decade	Articles	Share
1980s	28,089	7.0%
1990s	48,575	12.1%
2000s	74,660	18.5%
2010s	134,737	33.5%

Decade	Articles	Share
2020s	116,422	28.9%
Unknown year	15	0.0%

4.3 Authors per article

Authors	Articles	Share
1	374,748	93.1%
2	19,980	5.0%
3	2,985	0.7%
4	1,693	0.4%
5 or more	3,092	0.8%

4.4 Articles per author

Articles	Authors	Share
1	50,529	59.2%
2 to 9	30,153	35.3%
10 to 99	4,313	5.1%
100 or more	408	0.5%

4.5 Most frequent authors

Author	Articles
Jennifer Rubin	5,067
George F Will	3,877
Paul Krugman	3,541
EJ Dionne Jr	3,077
David Ignatius	2,716
Ellen Goodman	2,569
Thomas L Friedman	2,381
Nicholas Kristof	2,363
Jeff Jacoby	2,353
Maureen Dowd	2,315
James Freeman	2,303
Richard Cohen	2,273
David S Broder	2,227
Paul Waldman	2,153
Joan Vennochi	2,146

4.6 How the names were read

Read	Count	Share
as_written	430,599	95.5%
recovered	15,681	3.5%
manual_review	4,468	1.0%

5. Technical validation

- **Keys:** every article has its own ProQuest id; every link points to an article and an author that exist; every article has at least one author. The build stops otherwise.
- **Reasons:** they are matched to the records by file and position in the file, and the counts per reason add up to the rows parsed.
- **Review:** a review file with a repeated case, an unknown verdict or an unreadable correction stops the build, and so does a pair judged different that ends up merged. The reasons carry a fingerprint of the corrections they were computed with, and the tables and this document refuse reasons computed with other corrections.
- **Look-alike authors left apart** (kind / review):

Kind / review	Count	Share
conflicting_names / not_reviewed	1,674	30.9%
no_shared_newspaper / not_reviewed	1,211	22.4%
nickname / not_reviewed	854	15.8%
one_letter_apart / not_reviewed	797	14.7%
conflicting_names / different	227	4.2%
conflicting_names / unsure	170	3.1%
one_letter_apart / different	142	2.6%
nickname / different	91	1.7%
nickname / unsure	87	1.6%
no_shared_newspaper / unsure	74	1.4%
no_shared_newspaper / different	38	0.7%
one_letter_apart / unsure	24	0.4%
swapped_names / not_reviewed	17	0.3%
apart_by_review / different	5	0.1%
apart_by_review / not_reviewed	3	0.1%
swapped_names / different	2	0.0%
swapped_names / unsure	2	0.0%

6. Usage notes and limitations

- **Unsigned opinion is absent:** 659,374 opinion pieces have no author, mostly editorials. They are in the raw table.
- **Bylines that name nobody:** 11,076 articles, signed by an editorial board, a publication or a role.

- **Authors may still be split:** of the 5,418 look-alike pairs, 4,556 were not reviewed, most because one of the two authors has a single article. 357 were reviewed and left unsure.
- **Authors may be wrongly merged:** the rule needs a shared newspaper and compatible names, which two people with a common name can meet.
- **Readers' letters:** letters to the editor count as opinion, so many authors with one article are readers.
- **One word is never a name:** pen names of one word and bylines cut to one word are lost.
- **Subtler duplicates** (reprints, edited versions under another title) are not detected.

7. Code availability

The pipeline is in the private repository `econ_corpus` [1]: `exclusions` and `reasons` (selection), `authors` and `bylines` (reading names), `identity` (one author), `review` and `review_cases` (manual review), `processed` (tables) and `datasheet_clean` (this document). Every rule and its evidence are in `docs/decisions.md`. `README.md` lists the commands, from `make parse` on, that regenerate the dataset and this document.

8. References

[1] J. C. Reyes, "econ_corpus: build and audit a corpus of U.S. newspaper opinion articles," GitHub repository, 2026. Accessed: Nov. 8, 2026. [Online]. Available: https://github.com/JuanReyes01/econ_corpus